Amid all this, Congress volunteers kept moving among all of us, greeting us warmly and asking if we had eaten or if they could do anything to make us comfortable. I managed to have short conversations with several Congress leaders who were kind enough to answer whatever questions I had. Hardly anyone spoke about politics. Rather, all conversations were related to nation-building. And many people were genuinely worried about the communal, casteist, political and patriarchal values that were dividing India. It was really heartening to see this. At the back of my mind, I kept thinking to myself: Was this really the Congress party, which the Bharatiya Janata Party kept tarnishing as elitist and disconnected from the grassroots?

While I was engrossed in this fantastic experience, I felt a tap on my shoulder and saw Nagorao smiling at me. ‘It’s time,’ he told me quietly. He escorted me, along with his colleague Hrishikesh Singh, who, on the Congress party’s behalf, had been managing the civil society arrangements from day one. We were bundled up in a vehicle and zoomed ahead before the Yatra began. The plan was to go and stand a bit ahead of the Yatra and then join it as Rahul approached.

Reaching the designated waiting spot, we waited for the Yatra to join us. There was a lull in the air, as the sun painted glorious hues of every shade against the arid Marathwada terrain. Stray villagers waited with anticipation for the Yatra as children played around. It didn’t seem as if there was a massive movement just about to hit this quiet Malgudi Days kind of place.

Before I knew it, the Yatra came in sight and Vikram Srinivas joined us. He was supposed to hand-hold me through the entire security cordon and get me into the inner security circle, where Rahul walked with a select few. ‘Don’t worry, it will be easy,’ Vikram assured me. Easier said than done! I had to pass through two security layers before I could finally reach Rahul. Rahul walked very fast, so the Yatra reached our waiting point quite soon.

But there were several people wanting to spend some time with him. Since this was the first day of the Yatra in Maharashtra, almost everyone wanted to make their presence felt. I literally felt dwarfed among the galaxy of well-known dignitaries. And so we were forced to keep shifting our